

Blue Mosque

The Blue Mosque in Istanbul is arguably the last great mosque of the classical period of Ottoman architecture (1437–1703). Its correct name is the Sultan Ahmed Mosque, but the popular title comes from the blue paint and 21,043 Iznik tiles, which cast an atmospheric glow. Designed by Sedefkar Mehmed Agha (c.1540–1617) on the site of the former Roman hippodrome, the mosque amalgamates some Byzantine elements of the neighbouring Hagia Sophia with traditions of Islamic architecture. With one main dome, six minarets and eight secondary domes, the Blue Mosque is surrounded on three sides by a marble courtyard, which includes an imperial lodge, double-height shops and a theological college. The main dome is 43 metres (141 ft) high and 23.5 metres (77 ft) in diameter. The interior is illuminated by over 260 stained-glass windows and hundreds of oil lamps hung from the ceilings. The Iznik ceramic wall tiles are decorated with flowers, fruit and cypresses, marble paving covers the floors, and the *mihrab* (a niche indicating the direction of Mecca) is also of fine marble.

